

Let's go, said Hermione, c'mon, Harry - Ron... They left; many people were staring at them as they went. Harry gl... ed back as they reached the door. Rita Skeeter's Quick-Quotes Quill was out it was zooming backward and forward over a piece of parchment on the table. Harry sped on, staring around, and soon the dwellings became more numerous; there were gardens of weed around some of them, and he even saw a pet grindylow tied to a stake outside one door. Merpeople were emerging on all sides now, watching him eagerly, pointing at his webbed hands and gills, talking behind their hands to one another. Harry sped around a corner and a very strange sight met his eyes. This, said Karkaroff, and Harry, peering around the edge of his cauldron, saw Karkaroff pull up the left-hand sleeve of his robe and show Snape something on his inner forearm. Oh, it's you, Ronan, said Hagrid in relief. How are yeh? He walked forward and shook the centaur's hand. Danger lies before you, while safety lies behind. Two of us will help you, whichever you would find. One among us seven will let you move ahead. Another will transport the drinker back instead. Two among our number hold only nettle wine. Three of us are killers, waiting hidden in line. Choose, unless you wish to stay here forevermore. - But maybe you've got to be related to Slytherin, so Dumbledore couldn't Dinky Duddydums, don't cry, Mummy won't let him spoil your special day! she cried, flinging her arms around him. Think you might find this useful for next year. Won't say no more here. Tell you when I see you.

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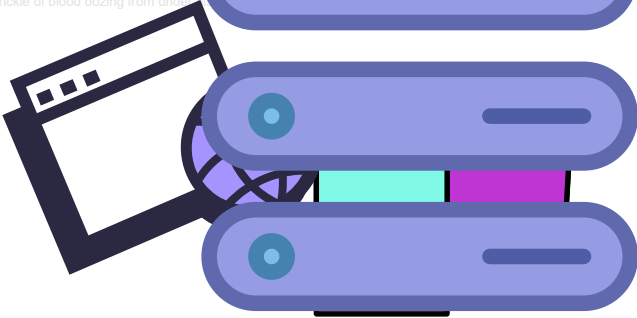
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Oh, well - you know - working hard, said Hermione. Close-up, Harry saw that she looked almost as tired as Lupin. Nevertheless, Sirius had been of some help to Harry, even if he couldn't be with him. It was due to Sirius that Harry now had all his school things in his bedroom with him. The Dursleys had never allowed this before, their general wish of keeping Harry as miserable as possible, coupled with their fear of his powers, had led them to lock his school trunk in the cupboard under the stairs every summer prior to this. But their attitude had changed since they had found out that Harry had a dangerous murderer for a godfather - for Harry had conveniently forgotten to tell them that Sirius was innocent. To everyone's delight except Harry's, there was to be another Hogsmeade trip on the very last weekend of the term. Professor McGonagall stared anxiously after them for a few moments, then waved her wand at her fallen books, causing them to soar up into the air and back into her arms. Hagrid had gone pale and sweaty. He dropped into one of his chairs and looked from Dumbledore to Cornelius Fudge. Bad business, Hagrid, said Fudge in rather clipped tones. Very bad business. Had to come. Four attacks on Muggle-borns. Things've gone far enough. Ministry's got to act. I never, said Hagrid, looking imploringly at Dumbledore. You know I never, Professor Dumbledore, sir - I want it understood, Cornelius, that Hagrid has my full confidence, said Dumbledore, frowning at Fudge. Blimey, I'm tired, yawned Fred, setting down his knife and fork at last. I think I'll go to bed and - You will not, snapped Mrs. Weasley. It's your own fault you've been up all night. You're going to de-gnome the garden for me, they're getting completely out of hand again - Oh, Mum - And you two, she said, glaring at Ron and George. You can go up to bed, dear, she added to Harry. You didn't ask them to fly that wretched car! Harry looked quickly around and spotted a large black cabinet to his left; he shot inside it and pulled the doors closed, leaving a small crack to peer through. Seconds later, a bell clanged, and Malfoy stepped into the shop. All rgh', Harry? Hagrid bellowed back, waving. See yeh at the feast if we don't drown! First years traditionally reached Hogwarts Castle by sailing across the lake with Hagrid.

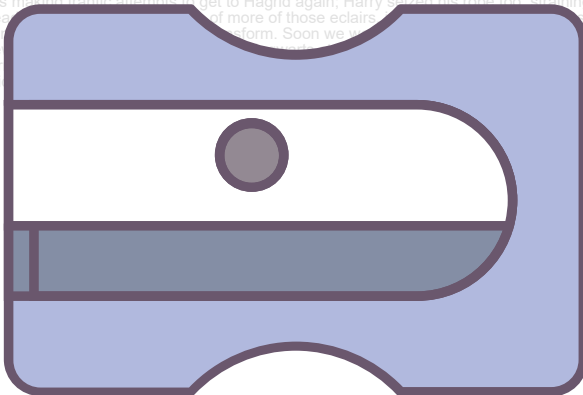
Yes, he said quietly, nine and a half inches... inflexible... rosewood... and containing... dear me... An 'air from ze 'ead of a veela, said Fleur. One of my grandmuzzer's. So Fleur was part veela, thought Harry, making a mental note to tell Ron... then he remembered that Ron wasn't speaking to him.Alohomora! The window sprang open.What? said Harry and Ron together, staring at her.Urgh aB" troll boogers. He wiped it on the troll's trousers. If it has, it's hiding them very well, said Ron. Maybe it's shy. I don't know why you don't chuck it, Harry. I wish I knew why someone did try to chuck it, said Harry. I wouldn't mind knowing how Riddle got an award for special services to Hogwarts either. Could've been anything, said Ron. Maybe he got thirty O.W.L.s or saved a teacher from the giant squid. Maybe he murdered Myrtle; that would've done everyone a favor But Harry could tell from the arrested look on Hermione's face that she was thinking what he was thinking.C'mon, said Fred, grabbing Ginny's hand and starting to pull her toward the wood. Harry, Ron, Hermione, and George followed. They all looked back as they reached the trees. The crowd beneath the Roberts family was larger than ever; they could see the Ministry wizards trying to get through it to the hooded wizards in the center, but they were having great difficulty. It looked as though they were scared to perform any spell that might make the Roberts family fall.Goyle's potion exploded, showering the whole class. People shrieked as splashes of the Swelling Solution hit them. Malfoy got a faceful and his nose began to swell like a balloon; Goyle blundered around, his hands over his eyes, which had expanded to the size of a dinner plate - Snape was trying to restore calm and find out what had happened. Through the confusion, Harry saw Hermione slip quietly into Snape's office.Harry vaulted over the locked park gate and set off across the parched grass. The park was as empty as the surrounding streets. When he reached the swings he sank onto the only one that Dudley and his friends had not yet managed to break, coiled one arm around the chain, and stared moodily at the ground. He would not be able to hide in the Dursleys' flower bed again. Tomorrow he would have to think of some fresh way of listening to the news. In the meantime, he had nothing to look forward to but another restless, disturbed night, because even when he escaped nightmares about Cedric he had unsettling dreams about long dark corridors, all finishing in dead ends and locked doors, which he supposed had something to do with the trapped feeling he had when he was awake. Often the old scar on his forehead prickled uncomfortably, but he did not fool himself that Ron or Hermione or Sirius would find that very interesting anymore. In the past his scar had warned that Voldemort was getting stronger again, but then it was Ron's turn. He was pale green by now. Harry crossed his fingers under the table and a second later the hat had shouted, GRYFFINDOR! Harry clapped loudly with the rest as Ron collapsed into the chair next to him.C'mon! Hagrid said angrily. I'm takin' yer all back up ter school, an' don' let me catch yeh walkin' down ter see me after dark again. I'm not worth that!I'm going down there, he said.I never touched Mrs. Norris! Harry said loudly, uncomfortably aware of everyone looking at him, including all the Lockharts on the walls. And I don't even know what a Squib is. Rubbish! snarled Filch. He saw my Kwispell letter! If I might speak, Headmaster, said Snape from the shadows, and Harry's sense of foreboding increased; he was sure nothing Snape had to say was going to do him any good.CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE THE YULE BALLSo what's the Order been doing? said Harry, looking around at them all.He didn't stop to think. Plunging a hand down the neck of his robes, he whipped out his wand and roared, Expecto Patronum! Something silver-white, something enormous, erupted from the end of his wand. He knew it had shot directly at the dementors but didn't pause to watch; his mind still miraculously clear, he looked ahead - he was nearly there. He stretched out the hand still grasping his wand and just managed to close his fingers over the small, struggling Snitch.I will not, said a stronger voice, in the back of his head, I won't answer....

Yeah, we thought Peeves seemed hacked off about something, said Ron darkly. So what did he do in the kitchens? On the usual, said Nearly Headless Nick, shrugging. Wreaked havoc and mayhem. Pots and pans everywhere. Place swimming in soup. Terrified the house-elves out of their wits - Clang!When the bell rang, everyone gathered up their things and headed for the door, Harry among them, but -Your father and I had been for a nighttime stroll, she said. He got caught by Apollyon Pringle - he was the caretaker in those days - your father's still got the marks. Fancy giving us a tour, Harry? said Bill.Dad! He was a bit of a mess, said Harry quietly. Shut up, Dudley. I'm warning you! Come and help me, Dad! Mum, come and help me! He's killed Cedric!No, no, it's scheduled for this afternoon, said Fudge, looking curiously at Ron.Look, I know you're having a hard time, I asked Dad, and he reckons I shouldn't have shouted.Now, see here, Dumbledore, he said, waving a threatening finger. I've given you free rein, always. I've had a lot of respect for your students without reference to the Ministry. But if you're going to work against me - There's no answer to this. He rocked backward and forward on his small feet for a moment and then he left the left sleeve of his robes as he went. He stuck out his forearm and showed it to Fudge, who slammed into the wall, then slid down it to the floor, a trickle of blood oozing from under his nose.



He's retired, used to work at the Ministry, said Charlie. I met him once when Dad took me in to work with him. He was an Auror - one of the best... a Dark wizard catcher, he added, seeing Harry's blank look. Half the cells in Azkaban are full because of him. He made himself loads of enemies, though... the families of people he caught, mainly... and I heard he's been getting really paranoid in his old age. Doesn't trust anyone anymore. Sees Dark wizards everywhere. Bill and Charlie decided to come and see everyone off at King's Cross station, but Percy, apologizing most profusely, said that he really needed to get to work.We know he's not coming in through Honeydukes, said Ron dismissively. We'd've heard if the shop had been broken into. Harry was glad Ron took this view. If the one-eyed witch was boarded up too, he would never be able to go into Hogsmeade again.Though he knew perfectly well that Percy was highly ambitious, Harry's impression was that Percy had not made a great success of his first job at the Ministry of Magic. Percy had committed the fairly large oversight of failing to notice that his boss was being controlled by Lord Voldemort (not that the Ministry had believed that - they all thought that Mr. Crouch had gone mad).Mum? he whispered. Dad? They just looked at him, smiling. And slowly, Harry looked into the faces of the other people in the mirror, and saw other pairs of green eyes like his, other noses like his, even a little old man who looked as though he had Harry's knobbly knees - Harry was looking at his family, for the first time in his life.Come along, Potter, she whispered. The thin line of her mouth was twitching as though she was about to cry. Come along... hospital wing... No, said Dumbledore sharply.I hope you told them to dress properly, these people, he snarled at once. I've seen the sort of stuff your lot wear. They'd better have the decency to put on normal clothes, that's all. Harry felt a slight sense of foreboding. He had rarely seen Mr. or Mrs. Weasley wearing anything that the Dursleys would call normal. Their children might don Muggle clothing during the holidays, but Mr. and Mrs. Weasley usually wore long robes in varying states of shabbiness. Harry wasn't bothered about what the neighbors would think, but he was anxious about how rude the Dursleys might be to the Weasleys if they turned up looking like their worst idea of wizards.Hagrid, who had told them last lesson that they had finished with unicorns, was waiting for them outside his cabin with a fresh supply of open crates at his feet. Harry's heart sank at the sight of the crates - surely not another skrewt hatching? - but when he got near enough to see inside, he found himself looking at a number of fluffy black creatures with long snouts. Their front paws were curiously flat, like spades, and they were blinking up at the class, looking politely puzzled at all the attention.Move! Harry shouted at it. C'mon! But nothing at Hogwarts had ever moved just because he shouted at it; he knew it was no good. He looked up and down the dark corridor. Perhaps Dumbledore was in the staffroom? He started running as fast as he could toward the staircase -

Some people reckon - Harry hesitated, then picked recklessly on, some people reckon he'd do anything to get the Defense Against the Dark Arts job. Lupin drained the goblet, pulled a face. Monday! How come they never wrote back to me? said Hagrid as Harry jogged alongside him (he had to take three steps to every stride of Hagrid's enormous boots). Harry explained all about Dobby and the Dursleys. FOURTEEN! See? Hermione whispered. See what would have happened? We've got to keep out of sight! No, Buckbeak! The hippogriff was making frantic attempts to get to Hagrid again; Harry seized his long pole, straining to hold Buckbeak back. They watched Hagrid meander tipsily up to the castle. He was gone. Buckbeak stopped fighting to get away. His head bowed, he looked down at the ground. "I'm getting there," Sirius said. "I'm getting there... well, highly exciting possibilities were open and the village by night. Sirius and James transformed into such large animals, they were able to keep a wary eye on the school grounds from above." "Form. Soon we will see if you can find a way to get rid of those who are looking around at the beaming and roaring the school grounds and the Hogwarts grounds and the world of magic. It was a very good idea. The earth was he to know how his



Look at this! said Malfoy in ecstasy, holding up Ron's robes and showing Crabbe and Goyle, Weasley's. They were, were you? I mean - they were very fashionable in about 1890 Ealt dung, Malfoy said Ron, the same color as the dress robes as he snatched the robes from him. Harry vaulted over the locked park gate and set off across the parched grass. The park was the only one that Dudley and his friends had not yet managed to break, coiled one arm around the chair and bed again. Tomorrow he would have to think of some fresh way of listening to the news. In the meantime, when he escaped nightmares about Cedric he had unsettling dreams about long dark corridors, all fire and trapped feeling he had when he was awake. Often the old scar on his forehead prickled uncomfortably anymore... In the past his scar hurting had warned that Voldemort was getting stronger again, but now it was to be expected... Nothing to worry about... old news... Ah yes, said Lupin, when Harry reminded him of the evening? The History of Magic classroom should be large enough... I'll have to think carefully about it. Still looks ill, doesn't he? said Ron as they walked down the corridor, heading to dinner. What d'you think Hermione, who had been sitting at the feet of a suit of armor, repacking her bag, which was so full of the chocolate, but still weak. Ron and Hermione kept looking at him sideways, as though frightened he'd fall back seat, where Harry, Ron, Fred, George, and Percy were all sitting comfortably side by side, and stepped into the front seat, which had been stretched so that it resembled a park bench. I mean, you'd never know they trundled out of the yard, Harry turning back for a last look at the house. He barely had time to work out Filibuster fireworks. Five minutes after that, they skidded to a halt in the yard so that Fred could run in and left her diary. By the time she had clambered back into the car, they were running very late, and temperaments were hanging open. Fleur, Cedric, and Krum all came in together. One side of Cedric's face was covered in a thick, dark, soot-like substance. He saw him. Could be useful, he said to Harry and Hermione as they went into dinner. Shall we go? Harry asked. The Great Hall. The long dining tables had vanished and a new set of tables had appeared along one wall, lit by thousands of candles floating overhead. The ceiling was velvety black once more and most of the school seemed to be packed beneath it.

